

SIVAS

Stars: Yellow

Known for: The Lotus Brotherhood, Courtisans of Gisaeng, Mining in the Great Rift

Exports: Food, Minerals

Imports: Technology

In a forgotten corner of the Quadrant of the Pillar lies the Sivas system. Far from the traditional trade routes of the Third Horizon, Sivas is home only to a small number of mining colonies, trade outposts, and the strange moon Karast.

OVERVIEW

The system's only connection to the outside world is the Janhagir Fleet of the Mogul clans. The Firstcome live alone here – sheltered from Zenithian expansion. To the few freighter crews who reach the system, Sivas and her planets appear to be a place frozen in time, with a culture governed by strange celestial phenomena. Despite this harsh first impression, travelers are tempted by the untold riches scattered across the celestial bodies that orbit the Sivas star. Fortune seekers should, however, take heed: the system is ferociously guarded by protective corsairs and distrustful Moguls.

SIVAS (PLANET)

This enormous rock planet is shrouded by a yellow-brown atmosphere above a smooth and strikingly featureless planet crust. The absence of tectonics and the dry atmosphere have resulted in a bleak landscape without any significant weather

patterns other than occasional dust storms and infrequent thunderclouds. The temperature rarely rises above freezing and the biting cold is relentless.

Remnants of large river systems and fossilised plants hint at a significantly more biodiverse past on Sivas, which now only harbors the occasional thorny thicket and frost-resistant weeds.

Despite its desolation, some visitors claim that a longer stay can be revitalizing for both mind and body. The planet's relatively strong gravity and thin atmosphere force the muscles, lungs and heart to acclimatize – providing visitors to Sivas a short-lived but life-affirming vitality when they return to their home planets.

SIVAS SYSTEM

Kala: Gas giant that is slowly approaching the sun.

Sivas: Desolate planet with colossal mountain ranges.

Karast: Peasant republic governed by the Lotus Brothers.

The Loulan trade station: Neutral but worn-down trading post.

Yovani: Scattered metal foundries owned by the Lotus Brothers.

Nurija: Ice planet containing one of the Foundation's research stations.

Gamhija: Ice planet devoid of colonies.

Comija: Ice planet rumored to host a Drakonite hideout.

LOULAN

The trade hub Loulan is permanently anchored in the Lagrange point formed by the planet Sivas and the system's star, and provides a haven for any unfortunate freighters that are denied landing permission on Karast or Sivas. The station is maintained by a motley crew led by the Jibre family. The family claims that

Loulan is the only legitimate trading post in Sivas thanks to an old treaty with the now-deposed farmers republic of Karast which states, "The Jibre shall be the right hand of the Merchant for as long as the lotus-covered hills of Karast shine blue in springtime". Today, this treaty is willfully ignored by the Moguls and anyone else who has no need of Loulan's services. Most outsiders, however, respect the claim because Loulan is the only neutral gathering spot for the system's visitors.

KARAST AND MEDDAIN

The system's largest population center is set on its smallest celestial body: the lush moon of Karast. While Sivas is a vast, inhospitable and monotone planet, Karast is covered in deep valleys filled with fertile soil, interrupted only by rippling springs and impassable mountains.

THE TEN FAMILIES

It is said that Karast's agricultural population is descended from the ten families, the founders who braved the systems of the Quadrant before settling on this tranquil moon orbiting Sivas. Karast is considered a tiny oasis among inhospitable giants. For a long time, Karast remained unknown among the people of the Third Horizon, allowing the society to transform into a true farmer's republic on the fringe of Firstcome expansion. Each valley had its own representative, and for more than 500 years, a farmer's council ruled from atop a barren mountain where not even a single date would grow – a location that would later become the capital of Meddain.



THE LOTUS BROTHERS

The Lotus Brothers, Karast's governing body, is said to originate from a world far beyond the Quadrant's borders. Only those in the innermost circles of the Brotherhood know of its precise origin. There are wild theories – ranging from a sect born on Dabaran to a religious congregation from Sadaal. The most common theory, and the one that most Karastians unite behind, is that the Brotherhood arrived during a period of severe crisis and it used this crisis to establish a strong position of power. The farmer's republic was crushed and a reactionary theocracy was formed in its place. For some, especially for those living in the teeming Meddain, the Brotherhood's arrival changed very little. For them, new opportunities opened up thanks to the administrative assignments provided by the Brotherhood. But in remote valleys, resistance is growing as farmers prepare for a day when they will rise up and reclaim their right of self-governance.

THE GISAENG

For outsiders, the Gisaeng act as the first contact with Karast's government. They guide visitors, negotiate with traders, and perform the administrative duties of the city. Their shining garb offers a strong contrast to the greyish-brown clothing favored by the masses of craftsmen and farmers that dominate the city's social strata. In many ways, the Gisaeng combine the duties of a civil servant with those of a courtesan. For ambitious Karastians, the Gisaeng is the highest achievable position in the social hierarchy.

